the venom that follows. If she doesn't address it, she worries that it will begin to slowly poison her. She tells me sometime later that it has been helpful to find someone who can listen, who is not social climbing or talking over the top and trying to fix everything. She says it is rare in her universe to meet someone who doesn't talk for the sake of it and that, as she speaks about her work and her life, maybe she was running away from something too – her own way of trying to get out and find someone else to be. Her success in navigating life since has been based on impulsivity and independence, and yet, although we don't say it or even know it at that moment, we are both looking for some new version of home to anchor our lives. Maybe she is trying to work out who she is too, without the modelling and without the rushing around to and from the long-term grief and the shock and turmoil she has harboured since. Maybe I am trying to work out who I might be without the cricket too.

Three months later, Daniella comes out to South Africa. I have been on tour throughout the whole winter, not picked in the side for any Test matches**.** She concedes, for the first time, that cricket might actually be a real job when she sees the size of the crowd in Johannesburg. She walks down the stairs, hears the noise, and has a moment of realisation that she might have misjudged how much people care about cricket. I have bowled badly, but she doesn't care or even know or understand what bowling badly means. As soon as she arrives and joins me at the hotel, I ask her to marry me. We have only known each other for three months, but I don't have a single doubt about it. I've known since the day I told Trescothick, the night after Elysium. I know it is the right thing to do. We go out in Johannesburg, looking for diamond rings as a winter of ushering drinks around, bowling in the nets and becoming frustrated at my own form becomes a secondary thought – cricket paling into the background of my life for the first time.

The only part of this quite complicated puzzle we are piecing together that she does not accept wholly and outright is my flat in Manchester. Around the back of a council block, my parents had found it during the World Cup last year. When Daniella is introduced to it, with its two lazy boys, one and a half bedrooms, a chair that has arms that pull out as a fridge for beers and an old-fashioned landline telephone, she tells me 'under no circumstances' is she going to live there. 'We need to find somewhere to live immediately,' she continues. I take one look at it, a part of my life that